The Investment Banking Networking Call

Cadence for a 30-minute call

Cadence

0:00 – 1:00 The open. Answer the "how are you" with something specific. Never just "I'm good."

1:00 – 5:00 Non-finance conversation. Sports, their city, weekend, school overlap, hobbies, travel, hopefully started by what you answered to "how are you?"

5:00 – 5:30 The pivot. When it dries up, ask permission and take control of the structure.

5:30 – 7:00 Your background. 90 seconds. Who you are, why finance, what you've done, what you want, why them.

7:00 – 22:00 Their story. You ask, they talk, you follow the thread. They should talk 60–70% of the call.

22:00 – 27:00 The ask. Advice first, referral second. Never reversed.

27:00 – 30:00 The close. End early. Thank them, confirm the next step, get off the phone.

The Open

"I'm good, how are you?" is a dead end. Give them something to grab onto.

"I'm good — just came from an IM basketball game, we lost by two but I'll take it."

"Doing well. Been up since six finishing a stock pitch for our investment group, so I'm running on coffee."

"Good — first sunny day here in three weeks, so campus is completely unusable."

Each one hands them an easy follow-up. Do your homework first — school, hometown, teams, LinkedIn.

The Pivot

When the small talk naturally dries up, do not let it go silent:

"Thanks again for doing this, I really appreciate it. Would it be okay if I told you a little about me, and then you tell me about you?"

Say it warmly and slightly quickly. Delivered stiffly it sounds rehearsed.

Questions

Have eight ready, expect to use four. Do not read them off a list. The best follow-up is usually "why?" or "what was that like?"

"How did you end up at [Firm]? Was banking always the plan or did you back into it?"

"What did last week actually look like for you, hour by hour?"

"What is the part of the job nobody warns you about?"

"What is the most interesting thing you've worked on in the last six months?"

"How does your group differ from other banks covering the same space?"

"What separates the analysts who get return offers from the ones who don't?"

"What do you wish you'd known as a sophomore that you know now?"

"When you look at a resume like mine, what is the first thing that stands out — good or bad?"

Never ask anything a two-minute Google search answers.

The Ask and the Follow-Up

"Based on everything we've talked about, what would you do in my position over the next three months?"

"Is there anyone else on your team, or in your network, who you think I'd benefit from talking to?"

If the call was flat, skip the referral ask. Send the thank-you within 24 hours: thank them, reference one non-finance thing from the call, name one piece of advice and what you'll do with it, confirm the next step. Then check back in six to eight weeks with a real update.